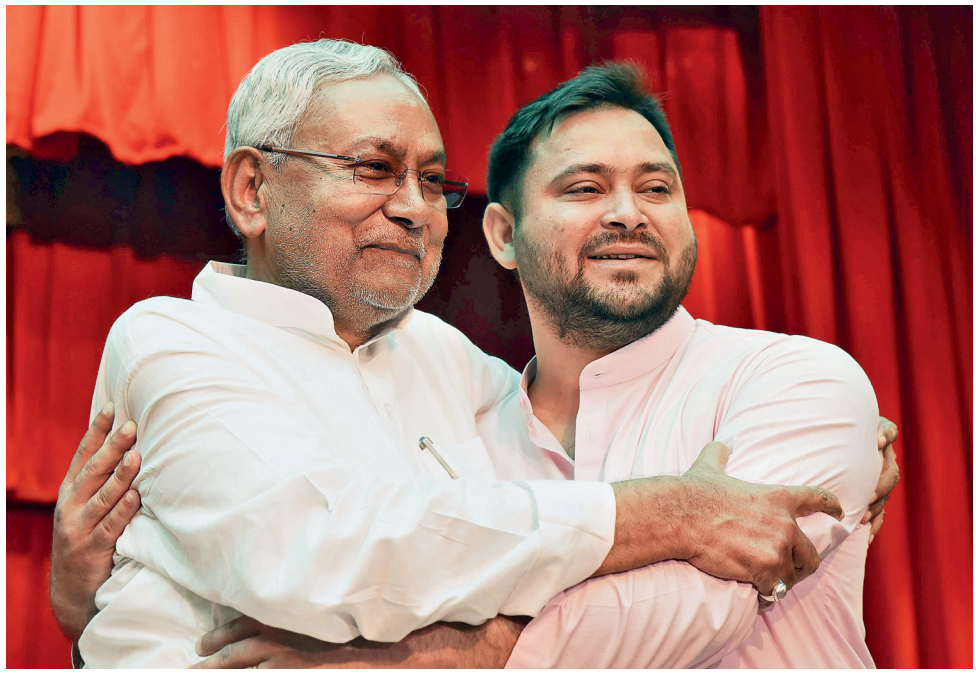
ANI



Bihar has 40 LS seats and the combined political capital of Nitish and Tejashwi makes the challenge for 2024 an enormous one for the BJP

NEW POWER EQUATION

Nitish and Tejashwi, the '*chacha-bhatija*' of Bihar politics, got together again after five years to turn the tables on the BJP

By Amitabh Srivastava

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NITISH KUMAR & TEJASHWI YADAV

Bihar Chief Minister and Deputy CM

It all seemed to be going on expected lines when lawmakers from Nitish Kumar's Janata Dal (United) or JD(U) voted for the BJP candidate, Jagdeep Dhankhar, in the vice-president elections on August 6. A day later, RJD leader Tejashwi Yadav, then leader of the opposition in Bihar, was leading one of his usual protest marches in Patna against the NDA government.

But in the next 48 hours, the two leaders scripted the perfect political coup, landing a sledgehammer blow on a clueless saffron side. As Nitish submitted his resignation on August 9, Tejashwi did a turnaround, pledging support of his legislators to a new government with the JD(U) chief again as chief minister.

Till now, the BJP had been seen as champions of "poll victories outside the EVM", poaching leaders and forming governments even when on the losing side. But they got a taste of their own medicine when Nitish dumped the party to form an alternative government with the RJD, Congress and four other parties. While the BJP was quick to criticise Nitish and Tejashwi for their "opportunism", the opposition camp saw this as a ray of hope for anti-BJP politics ahead of the 2024 Lok Sabha election. Indeed, Nitish and Tejashwi's surprise realignment could have a bigger impact on the national political canvas in the next two years.

Bihar, with its 40 Lok Sabha seats, has always been a high-stakes state for the BJP, where it has lost a formidable friend in 2022. In 2019, the BJP-led NDA had won 39 of the 40 seats. Now the BJP will have to rejig its Bihar strategy. Over the years, if the RJD had its formidable M-Y (the 16 per cent Muslim vote and 14 per cent Yadav) social support base, Nitish has had a similar cohort of the Extremely Backward Castes (EBCs) and the Mahadalits behind him. When the two parties had joined hands in the 2015 assembly polls, they had decimated the BJP. This was just a year after the BJP had conquered Bihar among other states in the 2014 Lok Sabha election, when Nitish and Lalu Prasad Yadav had contested against each other. While the 2024 Lok Sabha polls are still open-ended, the combined political capital of Nitish and Tejashwi has made the challenge for the BJP an enormous one in Bihar. ■